Soviets as part of war reparations. Yazov and his men boarded the liner in Kronstadt on August 23. When he came on board, a colonel who was doing the count gave him the number 1,230. The liner's capacity of 330 passengers was being exceeded at least fourfold.[11]

Yazov commanded an infantry regiment and was sent to Cuba with ground troops assigned to protect the missile installations, but he did not initially know his destination. Only after the ship left the Baltic and entered the North Sea did the ship's captain, the obligatory KGB officer, and Yazov, who commanded the military detachment, open the first envelope in the captain's safe. The orders were to head for the English Channel and open another envelope once they had cleared it. By that point they knew what was going on: along with new orders, the envelope contained a twenty-eight-page note on the history of Cuba, probably inserted by mistake. This was the first ocean voyage for most of the infantrymen, who suffered considerably from seasickness. The storms that buffeted the *Victory* for most of the sixteen-day voyage left almost no one willing or even capable of going on deck, lessening the possibility of discovery by surveillance planes and boats. They reached Nipe Bay on the northern coast of Cuba on September 10.[12]

On the long trip to Cuba Yazov befriended the captain of the *Victory*, Ivan Pismenny. Both men were veterans of World War II, dedicated communists and Soviet patriots. Their discussions ranged over political and social issues, and one of them focused on the future. The first generation of revolutionaries was aging, as was the first generation of youth raised by the Soviet regime, to which Yazov and Pismenny had belonged. Many old-timers found the new generation that had come of age during Khrushchev's de-Stalinization campaign insufficiently dedicated to communist ideals, and Pismenny was concerned about the prospects. "We're going to lose the young people, I feel it in my heart—we're going to lose them!" he fretted. Yazov was more optimistic. "You're exaggerating there," he told his new friend. "Look at the new recruits sailing with us. They're village boys, independent, you won't make them stray from the path."[13]

The KGB officers on the Soviet ships bound for Cuba would probably have sided with Pismenny rather than Yazov. Every KGB officer generally had half a dozen informers on board. They were instructed to make sure